

Memorandum

To: Dr. Ernest Gibson, Dr. Derek Ross, Dr. Susan Youngblood
From: Jolisa Brewster
Date: March 2026
Subject: Proposal for Funding Analysis
Keywords: grants, audience, rhetoric, genre, proposal, opportunities, problems

Purpose

For this analysis, I highlight the theoretical approaches applied in writing a grant-seeking proposal for a non-profit organisation in Dr. Candice Welhausen's graduate level Grant Writing course. In drafting our proposal, we followed the principles outlined in Johnson-Sheehan, R., & Hunter, P. T. (2024).

Audience and Context

As part of a two-member team, my colleague and I had the opportunity to work with a local non-profit organisation, O Grows' – a community garden that provides both fresh produce and learning enrichment programmes to the locals of Opelika, Alabama. The proposal for funding would be submitted to the Alabama Foundation Grant, whose mission is “to elevate the state and improve the quality of life for Alabamians” ([Alabama Power, n.d.](#)) in May 2026, and notice of funding success would be announced later in September 2026. As such the intended audience for this proposal would be internal grant funding reviewers and directors.

Theory and Application

Rhetorical State

Write clearly and plainly. This principle has been a constant reminder throughout my MTPC course, encouraging us to use straightforward sentences and paragraphs that expressed ideas effectively to readers (Johnson-Sheehan & Hunter, 2024, p.145). Rhetorical strategies play a significant role in effective grant writing by

shaping how a proposal communicates its purpose and persuade funders. With a strong focus on developing our proposal, we made sure to use the appropriate tone, and thoughtful integrated themes that appealed to the readers' emotions and values (Johnson-Sheehan & Hunter, 2024) as this approach helps to establish pathos while strengthening the overall persuasiveness of the proposal and likelihood of funding.

Identifying Need

For our non- profit organization, O Grows, we identified the need to obtain a new greenhouse. This addition would increase the production of fresh produce and expand year-round access within the local community, especially for individuals in low-income households. Food insecurity occurs when a household lacks access enough food because of insufficient income and other essential resources and is often driven by multiple interconnected factors, creating a cycle that can be difficult to break [Feeding America \(n.d\)](#). Addressing the needs of vulnerable community members is central to the organization's mission, and this focus guided our proposal, we took care not to suggest that the problem was impossible to solve or that the opportunity and already been missed (p.68-69) when stating our purpose within the proposal.

Request for Proposals (RFP)

The Request for Proposal (RFP) document outlines the background, need, project plan, budget, and justification. As part of our process, we researched and identified potential grants for our non- profit organisation and presented these options to our client. We successfully recommended the Alabama Foundation Grant based on the organization's immediate needs identified during on-site meetings.

References

Feeding America. (n.d.). Retrieved from <https://www.feedingamerica.org/hunger-in-america/alabama>

Grant, A. P. (n.d.). *Alabama Power Foundation*. Retrieved from Foundation Grant: <https://www.powerofgood.com/grants/foundation>

Richard-Johnson Sheehan, P. T. (2024). *Writing Proposals and Grants* (Third ed.). Parlor Press. Retrieved from <https://auburn-bookshelf.vitalsource.com/books/9781643174778>